

Meeting Minutes

Technical Working Group on Urban Recovery and Reconstruction Meeting

Date: 21 04 2016

Time: 3:00-5:00 pm

Location: Entrance Café, Lalitpur

Lead/Chairperson/Focal Point: Dr. Jennifer Duyne

Participants: By Organization

NRA, HRRP, IOM, UN Habitat, RedR India, Handicap International, Lumanti, Miyamoto Int. Nepal, UNICEF Nepal, Salvation Mission, University of Applied Sciences-Germany, Earth Observatory Singapore, NRCS, British Red Cross, JICA, SDC, Innovative Solutions, OXFAM, ADRA Nepal, Build Change, Emergency Architects, WHRC, SDC, UNRCO, Sansthaagat Bikas Sanjal

Agendas

1. Welcome note and briefing on the purpose of the meeting by Dr. Jennifer Duyne
2. Presentation on '*NRA's Urban Reconstruction Policy*' by Mr. Dhurba Sharma, Executive Member - NRA
3. Presentation on '*The impact of 2015 Earthquake on Housing and Livelihoods in Urban Areas in Nepal*' – Innovative Solutions
4. Discussion, Moderated by Mr. Padma Joshi and Dr. Jennifer Duyne
5. Conclusion and next steps
6. AOB
7. Action Points

1. Welcome and briefing on the purpose of the meeting by Dr. Jennifer Duyne

- Dr. Jennifer Duyne (HRRP) welcomed all the participants and introduced Mr. Dhurba Sharma (NRA) as the chief guest.
- She described the scenario that urban areas reconstruction process has been slightly neglected so far and emphasized that the Technical Working Group members present in the meeting could help in coming up with urban reconstruction plans and agendas for the way forward. She also proposed the POs use the HRRP platform to share information and to support the NRA with the reconstruction process in urban areas.
- Mr. Padma Joshi (UN-Habitat) gave a quick overview regarding the complexities, challenges and risks in urban reconstruction and drew attention to the potential for long term negative impacts if urban reconstruction is not addressed in a prompt manner. He encouraged the TWG members to bring together their experience and expertise to address complications and develop solutions.

2. Presentation on 'NRA's Urban Reconstruction Policy' by Mr. Dhurba Sharma, Executive Member – NRA

- Mr. Sharma thanked the HRRP for conducting crucial meetings, collaborating and conducting activities especially recent support for enrollment.
- He informed that the NRA Act included Rural Housing as a priority area. As such, the CBS survey is being conducted in rural areas for the damage assessment, which is on the verge of completion. The CBS Survey has categorized the damaged houses in 5 categories and the reconstruction grant of 2 lakhs NPRs will be provided only to those houses with damage categorized as 3-5. The NRA envisions providing some sort of repair assistance for houses falling under damage categories 1 and 2.
- After the approval and authorization of the eligible household list (produced from the survey data) by the NRA executive committee, the VDCs and municipalities will sign a 'participation agreement' with eligible households in coordination with the DDC – this is the primary objective of the enrolment process.
- After the completion of the assessment in rural areas, which is due soon, the NRA plans to roll out the damage assessment survey in the three valley districts.
- The NRA has developed different policy guidelines for the facilitation of the reconstruction process including the NRA Policy and Regulations, Land Acquisition Guidelines, Land Registration Guidelines, Public Procurement Guidelines, Guidelines for the disbursement of the reconstruction grant, NGO mobilization guidelines, and Housing Design Catalogue.
- Under the Urban Reconstruction Policy, the NRA will focus on owner driven reconstruction and will address requirements for additions / revisions to the building codes and housing standards and norms, as well as taking into account the particular needs of Heritage Settlements.
- NRA has disseminated information on seismic resilience standard housing through communications campaigns utilising a range of media channels.
- The NRA framework has been developed based on the 'Build Back Better' concept.
- The government has made an agreement with Nepal Rastra Bank to levy 2% interest rate loans of 1.5 million NPRs in rural areas, and 2.5 million NPRs in urban areas.
- The NRA requests maximum utilization of local materials, skills and technologies in the reconstruction process, and will look to support the transfer of settlements from seismically hazardous locations to safer ones.
- A 'top-up' grant of 50,000 NPRs will be provided to targeted vulnerable families.
- The NRA has completed the first draft (to be published soon) of the PDRF (Post Disaster Recovery Framework), that will guide its investment and operations for the coming five years.
- At the end, MR. Sharma urged POs to submit Expressions of Interest (EOIs) to the NRA in order to secure agreement for their projects from the NRA and move ahead with implementation.

3. Presentation on 'The impact of 2015 Earthquake on Housing and Livelihoods in Urban Areas in Nepal' – Innovative Solutions

The survey findings to date were presented by the consultancy team from Innovative Solutions who have been hired by the HRRP to carry out this piece of work. The survey was

conducted in 15 settlements across 7 areas with the objective of documenting the impacts of the earthquakes on housing and livelihoods to support the development of an approach and policies for the urban housing recovery and reconstruction process.

Present Scenario

- Loss of / decrease in income for families whose agricultural land is being used for temporary shelters
- Expenses increased for rent and other basic services
- Poor renters and informal settlers are the ones who have been impacted most and are forced to live in vulnerable situations due of lack of funds
- Difficulties with land permits, finances for reconstruction, and safe demolition of houses in dense neighborhoods
- Lack of clarity regarding government policies and eligibility criteria to receive grant money
- For the reconstruction of heritage areas, extra effort needs to be put both in terms of technical and financial support
- Cases of mental anxiety and even death amongst affected communities due to the loss of their homes and extreme weather conditions reported by the assessment
- Local festivals affected due to the damage of historical and cultural shrines

Relief and Recovery Initiatives

- Less support received in the core urban and peri-urban areas as compared to suburbs and historical towns

Reconstruction Process

- Demolition of vulnerable houses yet to be carried out (especially in suburbs)
- Delay in reconstruction grant being disbursed is a major constraint in the reconstruction process; other constraints include: land issues, plot sizes, and building permits
- Communities have initiated their own reconstruction process, making an effort to resolve their lives and livelihoods
- Communities have shown interest in planned settlements and land pooling But there is a need for stronger policies in these areas to support implementation
- 2.5 million NPRs and 1.5 million NPRs loans, at 2% interest rate, to be available for reconstruction in the Kathmandu valley and outside the Kathmandu valley, respectively
- Major challenge in urban reconstruction process lies in planning and providing technical support
- Reconstruction planning needs to be done carefully for future security

4. Discussion, Moderated by Mr. Padma Joshi and Dr. Jennifer Duyne

- a. “At the beginning, you mentioned that renters are a particularly vulnerable group as a result of the earthquake, but then focused on the financial mechanism for reconstruction. What has been considered in terms of support for renters?”**

- b. British Red Cross indicated that an area it is felt that the TWG should look at is community planning, and in particular, WASH in the urban housing recovery and reconstruction discussions and planning.
- c. Miyamoto highlighted that the focus of the assessment, and its findings, was the most damaged buildings and areas; however, the seismic vulnerabilities in areas that were not so heavily damaged remains very high and urban recovery and reconstruction should consider, and where possible, address this situation.
- d. **Are there any added incentive approaches for the reconstruction of private heritage homes within traditional settlements?**
 - Currently, there are no incentives available for reconstruction of traditional settlements. Communities are very interested to receive technical support for reconstruction of traditional settlements. Where municipalities have potential to provide grants to incentivise traditional reconstruction, the bureaucratic process has been found to be extremely long which was seen as a constraint by many people.
- e. **Is the whole community of Pilachen eligible to receive the reconstruction grant and the 2% interest loan from government? If not, how are the communities planning to finance reconstruction?**
 - No, very few households in Pilachen have been found to be eligible for the reconstruction grant. They are looking to commercial banks for loans to finance the reconstruction. Many are already moving ahead with construction and feel that the GoN reconstruction grant will take a long time and have a long process so they prefer to mobilise their own finances, however possible.
- f. **The presentation indicated that municipalities have been given the responsibility to manage reconstruction but seem to lack capacity to do so. Is this being addressed or is this a bottleneck?**
 - Municipalities need to have authority from the national level for any such procedures, so it is time consuming. Municipalities are under pressure to create guidelines and policy but often without sufficient capacity or support. Need to better understand the situation in order to understand what support municipalities require and how.

5. Conclusion and Next Steps

- Once the urban impact assessment is complete, the full set of findings and recommendations will be presented to the Urban Recovery and Reconstruction TWG, and all HRRP partners.
- Based on the findings and recommendations, the TWG members to review which areas require additional work, and what outputs the TWG can develop in support of this.
- A workshop will be organised between TWG members and the NRA to define a plan and actions based on the findings and recommendations of the urban impact assessment.

6. AOB

- The scheduled presentation by IOM-CCCM, University of Zurich, Earth Observatory and University of Singapore were not delivered due to time constraints. However, their presentations will be delivered in subsequent meetings of the TWG
- Lumanti informed that they have organized a week long workshop on settlement planning which starts on the 25th April and runs until the 1st May. All interested partners are invited to attend the closing session of the workshop in the afternoon on May 1st, in Entrance Café

7. Action Points

1. Workshop to be organized between NRA and TWG members in mid-May to review final set of findings and recommendations from urban impact assessment and define plans and actions
2. ToRs for working groups on key areas, e.g. community engagement, repair / retrofit, and heritage settlements, to be prepared

Next Meeting

TBD

Meeting Participants List/Attendance Sheet

SN	Name	Organization	Phone Number	Email
1	Manish Mehta	RedR India	9810362035	manishkymar@redrindia.org
2	Pralhad Karki	RedR India	9818280205	pralhad@redrindia.org
3	Nicole Preston	Handicap International	9810183104	inclusion.co@handicap-international-npl.org
4	Ruji Rajbhandari	HRRP/Lumanti	9843368569	ruji@hrrpnepal.org
5	Samrachhika Manandhar	HRRP/Lumanti	9841802778	samrachhika@hrrpnepal.org
6	Brian Planas	Miyamoto International Nepal		bplanas@miyamotointernational.com
7	Asim Shrestha	UNICEF, Nepal	9851024987	ashrestha@unicef.org
8	Kathy Crombie	Salvation Mission	9823299523	kathy_crombie@salvationarmy.org
9	Richard Vanlalnghaka	Salvation Mission	9823299523	Nepal-FieldTeam@salvationarmy.org
10	Sara Moktan	Salvation Mission	9860487787	moktansaara@gmail.com
11	Padma Sunder Joshi	UN Habitat	9851124763	ps.joshi@unhabitat.org.np
12	Rupesh Shrestha	Uni of Applied Sciences, Germany	9841945089	rupeshshrestha2005@gmail.com
13	Pia Hollenbach	WHRC	9823432316	pia.hollenbach@geo.uzh.ch
14	Patrick Daly	Earth Observatory Singapore		PatrickDaly@ntu.edu.sg
15	Sandhya Aryal	IOM	9801108451	saryal@iom.int
16	Laxman Chhetry	Nepal Red Cross	9851221991	
17	Dipak Giri	Nepal Red Cross	9851097469	dipak.giri@ncrs.org
18	Pete Jones	British Red Cross	9808492967	petejones@redcross.org.uk
19	Ghazala Naeen	JICA	9851107206	ghazala.gha@hotmail.com
20	Ivan Vuarambon	SDC		
21	Gaurav Aryal	Sansthaagar Bikas Sanjal	9802030272	gaurav@sanjal.org.np
22	Roshan S	Innovative Solution	9841934228	
23	Kishore Manandhar	Innovative Solution	9841531924	
24	Kabita Shrestha	Innovative Solution	9841201366	kabitabs@mail.com.np
25	Bijaya K. Shrestha	Innovative Solution	9841347187	bkshrestha@hotmail.com
26	Bhushan Shrestha	Innovative Solution	9851082139	sbhushan@mail.com.np
27	Ram Thapaliya	NRA		
28	Dhurba Sharma	NRA		
29	Sudin Pradhan	Oxfam	9851207635	supradhan@oxfam.org.uk
30	Lajana Manandhar	Lumanti	9851035594	lajana@lumanti.org.np
31	Binat Malla	ADRA Nepal	9841459212	binat.malla@adranepal.org
32	Liva Shrestha	BUILD CHANGE	9841352100	liva@buildchange.org
33	Sarah Hannow	Emergency Architects	9860276128	shannow2@archi-urgent.com
34	Dibyeswar		9841497514	sdibyaswar@yahoo.com

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Contact detail: Dr. Jennifer Duyne

	Shrestha			
35	Shriju Pradhan	NRA	9851088747	shriju.pradhan@gmail.com
36	Jeniffer Duyne	HRRP	9801127843	jennifer.duyne@hrrpnepal.org
37	Babar Tanwir	HRRP	9801108449	babar@hrrpnepal.org
38	Binita Shrestha	HRRP	9841429932	binita@hrrpnepal.org
39	Ajit Thakali	HRRP	9843128092	ajit@hrrpnepal.org
40	Shailesh Acharya	HRRP	9851191411	shailesh@hrrpnepal.org
41	Sona Shrestha	HRRP	9813864089	sona@hrrpnepal.org
42	Sabita Purkoti	HRRP	9843386821	sabita@hrrpnepal.org
43	Jeny Shrestha	HRRP	9841408545	jeny@hrrpnepal.org
44	Moir Reddick	UN RCO	-	moira.reddick@one.un.org